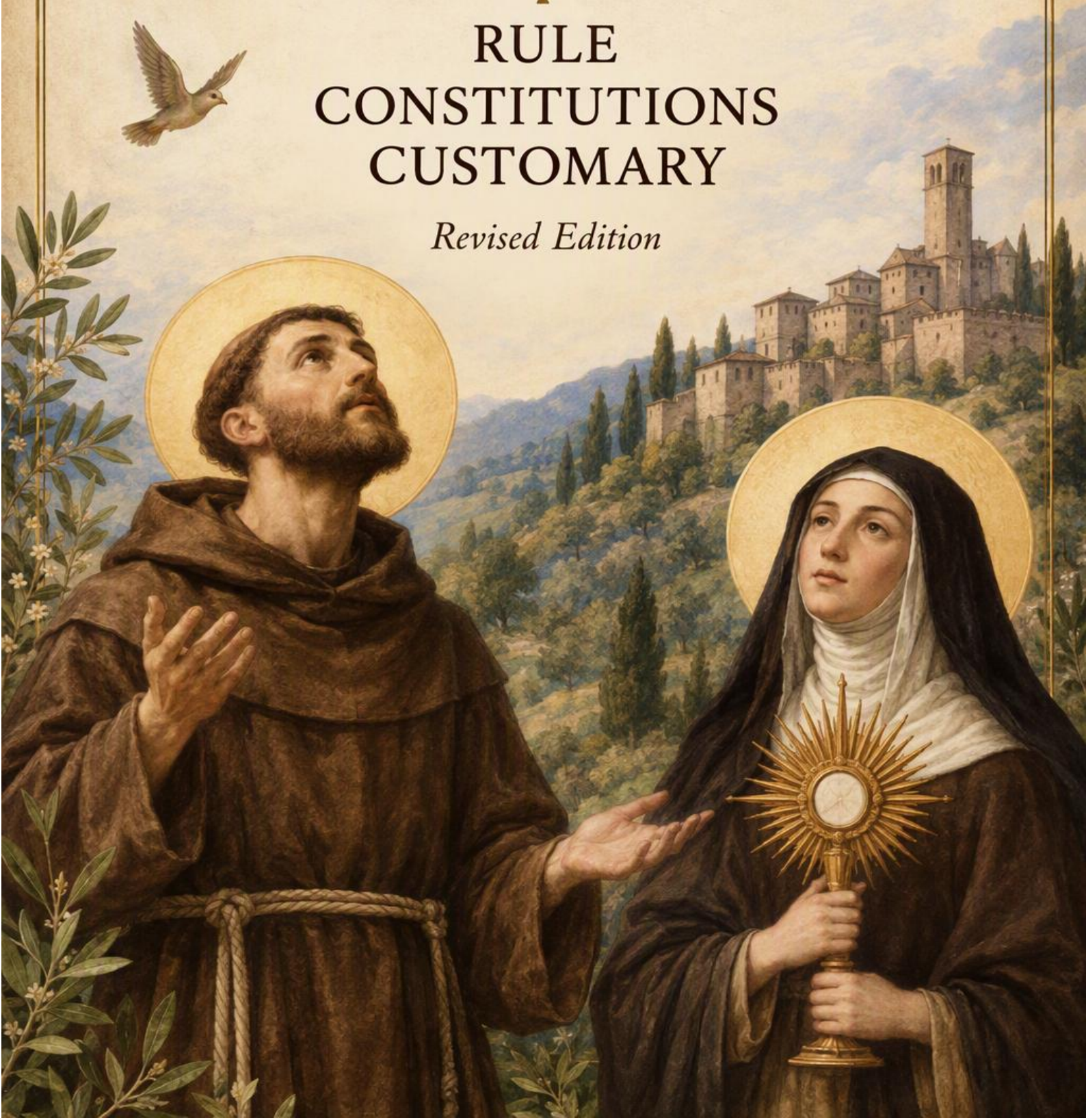
ORDER OF SAINTS FRANCIS AND CLARE

RULE
CONSTITUTIONS
CUSTOMARY

Revised Edition



The GOVERNING DOCUMENTS *of* THE ORDER OF SAINTS FRANCIS AND CLARE



RULE • CONSTITUTIONS • CUSTOMARY

A Franciscan Religious Order
within the Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church

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GENERAL INTRODUCTION

1. The Rule, Constitutions and Customary of the Order of Saints Francis and Clare form a single, ordered expression of one vocation: to follow Jesus Christ according to the Holy Gospel in the spirit of Saint Francis and Saint Clare of Assisi. They are offered not simply as regulations for an organisation, but as instruments of conversion by which a fraternity may receive the Gospel more deeply, embody it more faithfully and bear its peace more generously within the Church and the world. Their purpose is to help each brother and sister recognise the call of Christ in prayer, Sacrament, Scripture, fraternity, ordinary labour, family life, service of people who are poor or excluded, and reverent care for the whole created order.

2. These three texts possess distinct but complementary functions. The Rule sets forth the spiritual form of life and names the evangelical vision by which all other provisions are to be judged. The Constitutions give that vision stable juridical and communal expression, defining the responsibilities, structures, safeguards and processes necessary for a healthy religious order. The Customary translates both into an ordinary rhythm of prayer, formation, fraternity, work, simplicity, mission and mutual care. None should therefore be read in isolation: the Rule gives the Constitutions and Customary their soul; the Constitutions protect the integrity and accountability of the common life; and the Customary ensures that the professed vocation is embodied in concrete, sustainable practice.

3. The Order is principally dispersed. Its members may be lay or ordained, married or single, employed or retired, living alone, within a family, or in an intentional religious household. This diversity does not weaken the common vocation, but reveals how Franciscan life may sanctify the varied circumstances in which God's people are called to holiness. The home may become a little friary or convent of the heart; the workplace a field of honest witness; the local church a place of sacramental communion; and the neighbourhood a school of mercy, peace and attentive presence. Dispersion must never become isolation: members are bound together by profession, prayer, formation, accountable relationships, practical care and a shared mission.

4. The texts are to be received with evangelical seriousness and pastoral wisdom. Fidelity is not measured by rigid uniformity, nor may adaptation become an excuse for indifference. Health, disability, family responsibility, employment, poverty, age and genuine necessity require compassion and prudent accommodation, while the essential spirit of prayer, simplicity, chastity according to one's state of life, obedience, minority, fraternity and service remains binding upon all. Authority within the Order is always ministerial: it exists to guard vocation, protect persons, promote justice, sustain communion and help the least voice to be heard. No appeal to obedience, custom, office or spiritual intimacy may override conscience properly formed, safeguarding, civil law, human dignity or the Gospel of Christ.

5. Those who read this document for discernment, formation, profession, government or review are invited to do so prayerfully. Its provisions are not a substitute for the living voice of the Holy Spirit, the discernment of the Church, mature conscience or fraternal charity. Rather, they provide a trustworthy framework within which these may flourish without arbitrariness or confusion. The true interpretation of every paragraph will be seen in its fruits: deeper love of God, greater conformity to Christ, reverence for the Sacraments and Holy Scripture, humility in authority, safety for the vulnerable, tenderness within fraternity, integrity in public and private life, and joyful service without desire for status or reward.



THE RULE

of the Order of Saints Francis and Clare

PREAMBLE

6. The Rule and Life of the brothers and sisters of the Order of Saints Francis and Clare is to observe the Holy Gospel of Our Lord Jesus Christ, following in the footsteps of Christ after the examples of Saint Francis and Saint Clare of Assisi. This Gospel life is received as a gift before it is undertaken as a duty: the Lord calls each member to conversion, gathers the fraternity, and sends it to become an instrument of mercy, reconciliation and peace. Members therefore promise to seek Christ in prayer and Sacrament, in the Church and Holy Scripture, in one another, in people who are poor or excluded, and in the whole created order.

7. Members may be married or single, lay or ordained, celibate or living faithfully within marriage, employed or retired, living alone, with family, or in an intentional religious household. The ordinary form of the Order is dispersed life, yet no member is to live the vocation in isolation. Physical distance is overcome by common profession, prayer, fellowship, formation, mutual care and shared mission. Each member shall interpret this Rule with evangelical seriousness and pastoral wisdom, adapting its observance to health, family, work and genuine necessity without losing its spirit.

8. This form of life is rooted in the mystery of the Most Holy Trinity and in the humility of the Incarnate Word. With Saint Francis and Saint Clare, members shall contemplate the Son of God who emptied himself, became poor for our sake, washed the feet of his disciples and gave himself in the Eucharist and upon the Cross. Led by the Holy Spirit, they shall return every good to the Father, from whom all goodness comes, and seek to become conformed to Christ in humility, poverty, obedience and self-giving love.

CHAPTER I PURPOSE AND FRANCISCAN IDENTITY

9. *The vocation of the Order begins not with a programme of religious activity but with the person of Jesus Christ. As Francis heard the Lord address him through the Gospel, so each member is called to receive the words and deeds of Christ as a living summons. Franciscan identity is therefore evangelical, ecclesial, fraternal and missionary. It is recognised not chiefly by dress, title or office, but by humility, mercy, simplicity, joy, reverence and practical love.*

10. **1. The Holy Gospel.** The Gospel of Jesus Christ is the first and highest rule of the Order, and all proper law, custom and personal discipline shall serve this Gospel purpose. Members shall receive the Gospel not merely as teaching but as the revelation of the living Christ, poor, humble, crucified and risen. They shall read the Gospels frequently, hear them within the liturgy, receive their words with a humble and ready heart, and ask how Christ is to be followed here and now. They shall move continually from Gospel to life and from life to Gospel, allowing the Word to judge, console and convert them, so that the life of Jesus may become visible in their prayer, relationships, work and service.

11. To observe the Gospel means more than admiring it. Members shall hear it in the liturgy, study it personally and in fraternity, meditate upon it prayerfully and translate it into concrete choices. In discernment they shall attend especially to the life and teaching of Jesus, his poverty and humility, his compassion for the vulnerable, his truthfulness before power, his forgiveness of enemies, his table fellowship, his prayer to the Father and his self-offering upon the Cross. No interpretation of this Rule may be used to excuse conduct plainly contrary to the spirit of Christ.

"The Rule and life of the Lesser Brothers is this: to observe the Holy Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ."

— Saint Francis, Later Rule, I

12. **2. Francis and Clare.** Members shall follow Christ after the examples of Saint Francis and Saint Clare, cherishing poverty of spirit, contemplation, minority, peace, joy, service and reverence for creation. They shall learn from Francis that conversion begins when the Lord leads a person towards those whom fear or society has kept at a distance, so that what was bitter may, through mercy, become sweetness. They shall learn from Clare to gaze upon Christ, ponder his life, contemplate his humility and desire to imitate him with an undivided heart.

"Gaze upon Him, consider Him, contemplate Him, as you desire to imitate Him."

— Saint Clare, Second Letter to Agnes of Prague

13. Members shall become familiar with the principal Franciscan sources, especially the Earlier Rule, the Later Rule, the Testament of Saint Francis, his Admonitions and Praises, and the writings and witness of Saint Clare. They shall receive these sources neither as museum pieces nor as texts to be copied without regard to circumstance, but as authoritative witnesses to a charism that must be embodied faithfully in the present age. Francis's insistence that the Lord gave him brothers shall shape the Order's understanding that fraternity is received, not selected only according to preference.

14. After the example of Saint Clare, members shall contemplate Christ as the mirror in whom the poverty of the manger, the humility of public ministry, the charity of the Cross and the glory of resurrection are revealed. Contemplation shall lead to

transformation: what members gaze upon in Christ they shall seek to embody in their own lives. They shall hold together contemplation and loving service, guarding the interior dwelling place of the heart while allowing prayer to make them more available to the needs of others.

"After the Lord gave me some brothers, no one showed me what I had to do, but the Most High Himself revealed to me that I should live according to the pattern of the Holy Gospel."

— Saint Francis, Testament

15. **3. Ecclesial life.** The Order lives within the Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church and receives the sacramental, liturgical and apostolic life of the Church with gratitude and reverence. Following Saint Francis and Saint Clare, members shall love the Church not as an abstract institution but as the Body of Christ in which the Gospel is proclaimed, the Sacraments are celebrated and diverse vocations are gathered into communion. They shall show particular reverence for the Holy Eucharist, the words of Scripture and those entrusted with sacramental and teaching ministry. They shall work humbly for the Church's holiness and renewal, remaining faithful to the Gospel, properly formed conscience, safeguarding obligations and lawful ecclesiastical discipline.

16. **4. One fraternity.** Friars and sisters form one spiritual family, received from the Lord as gift and responsibility. Ordination, gender, marital status, occupation, wealth, education, health or office establish no higher grade of religious dignity. Members shall honour one another's gifts, bear one another's burdens, correct with gentleness, rejoice in another's good and ensure that no one is abandoned in sickness, poverty, grief or isolation.

17. Fraternity requires regular presence, truthful communication and a willingness to remain in relationship when differences arise. Members shall avoid cliques, favouritism and competition. Decisions affecting common life should be approached through prayer, consultation and attention to quieter voices. Where tension occurs, members shall distinguish ordinary disagreement from misconduct, seek direct and charitable conversation where appropriate, and use safeguarding or formal procedures whenever protection, justice or accountability require them.

18. Following Saint Clare's form of life, members shall make known their needs to one another with confidence and shall respond with the tenderness of a mother caring for her child. Fraternal love shall be practical as well as affectionate, attentive to food, shelter, illness, grief, loneliness, disability and spiritual distress. Those who receive care shall do so without shame, and those who give it shall avoid possessiveness or control. In this way the fraternity shall become a place where the charity of Christ is both proclaimed and experienced.

CHAPTER II PRAYER AND CONVERSION

19. *Prayer is the breath of the Franciscan life and conversion its daily movement. Following Francis, members shall desire above all things to possess the Spirit of the Lord and his holy activity. Devotion is not withdrawn from life: it purifies desire, orders action, exposes self-deception and makes the heart available for mercy. The disciplines of this chapter are therefore means of communion, freedom and renewal rather than measures of spiritual status.*

"Let them desire above all things to have the Spirit of the Lord and His holy activity."

— Saint Francis, Later Rule, X

20. **5. Daily prayer.** Members shall maintain a faithful rhythm of Morning and Evening Prayer, Scripture, personal prayer, intercession and recollection, adapted reasonably to health, family and work. Prayer shall not be treated merely as a task completed, but as the daily turning of the whole person towards God. When the full Office cannot be prayed, a simpler form shall be used faithfully rather than prayer being abandoned.

"Place your mind before the mirror of eternity; place your soul in the brilliance of glory."

— Saint Clare, Third Letter to Agnes of Prague

21. The ordinary pattern shall include an offering of the day, Morning and Evening Prayer, a passage of Holy Scripture, intercession for the Church, the world, the Order and those in need, and a brief examination before rest. Members should cultivate periods of silence, lectio divina and contemplative prayer according to capacity. Persistent difficulty in prayer should be shared honestly with a suitable companion; dryness is not failure, and illness, disability, caring duties or crisis call for compassionate adaptation rather than abandonment of the life of prayer.

22. **6. Eucharist.** The Holy Eucharist shall stand at the heart of the Order's life. Members shall participate regularly according to opportunity and ecclesiastical discipline, preparing with recollection and responding with thanksgiving and service. With Saint Francis, they shall contemplate in the Eucharist the same humility by which the Son of God descended into the poverty of human flesh and continues to give himself under humble signs. They shall reverence Christ's sacramental presence and allow his self-emptying love to shape their use of time, possessions and authority, their relationships with others, and their willingness to become lesser ones in service.

23. In the Eucharist members contemplate the humility of God, who gives himself under ordinary signs and gathers many into one Body. They shall approach with faith, prepare by reconciliation where needed, participate attentively and continue the liturgy through works of mercy. Churches, vessels, reserved Sacrament and the written words by which the mysteries are celebrated shall be treated with fitting care. Eucharistic devotion must bear fruit in reverence for Christ present in people who are hungry, wounded, rejected or forgotten.

"In this world, I see nothing materially of the most high Son of God except His most holy Body and Blood."

— Saint Francis, Testament

24. **7. Conversion and penance.** The Franciscan life is a continuing return to God. Members shall practise honest examination of life, repentance, forgiveness, restitution where harm has been done, and reconciliation wherever possible. They shall make responsible use of sacramental confession, spiritual direction and

pastoral counsel, avoiding both complacency and scrupulosity, and trusting that mercy calls the sinner not to shame but to renewed faithfulness.

> "The Lord gave me, Brother Francis, thus to begin doing penance."
>
> *— Saint Francis, Testament*

25. **8. Contemplation, fasting and praise.** Members shall safeguard silence and contemplation so that action may arise from prayer and prayer may open the heart to service. They shall practise suitable fasting or another penitential discipline, particularly on Fridays and in the Church's penitential seasons, with due regard for health and family duties. In every circumstance they shall cultivate gratitude and praise, recognising every good as coming from God and returning all honour to him.

26. Penance shall ordinarily include moderation, almsgiving, voluntary service, restraint in speech and consumption, and willing acceptance of the ordinary costs of faithful love. Members shall not undertake extreme practices without prudent advice, nor impose private disciplines upon others. The fullest sign of penance is a changed life: pride yielding to humility, resentment to forgiveness, wastefulness to stewardship, avoidance to compassionate presence, and self-protection to responsible service.

CHAPTER III THE EVANGELICAL COUNSELS

27. *The evangelical counsels conform the member to Christ in freedom and love. In a dispersed order they are not reduced to monastic forms, nor diluted into vague aspiration. Simplicity orders the use of goods; chastity orders love and relationship; obedience orders freedom towards God and the common good; minority orders power as service. Each counsel shall be interpreted according to vocation and circumstance, but all members are accountable for its sincere practice.*

28. **9. Simplicity and poverty of spirit.** Members may own property, earn income and provide prudently for spouses, children, dependants, health and old age. Yet, in the spirit of Saint Francis and Saint Clare, they shall seek to live without anything of their own: not by denying lawful ownership or family responsibility, but by refusing possessiveness and receiving all things as gifts entrusted by God for responsible use and generous sharing. They shall hold all goods as stewards, resist the illusion that possessions confer security, worth or superiority, review their consumption, avoid needless luxury and remain ready to give. Franciscan poverty shall be expressed through simplicity, gratitude, solidarity with people who are poor, freedom from greed and dependence upon divine providence, so that concern for property never closes the heart to a neighbour in need.

"Those who came to receive life gave whatever they had to the poor… We desired nothing more."

— Saint Francis, Testament

29. Members shall make periodic, honest review of income, expenditure, possessions, debt, investments and patterns of consumption. They shall seek lawful and ethical use of resources, avoid waste and ostentation, and practise regular giving proportionate to means. Decisions about housing, transport, technology, clothing and leisure should reflect sufficiency rather than display. Those with abundance should ask how it may serve others; those experiencing poverty shall not be shamed, and receiving assistance shall never be treated as failure in Franciscan life.

30. **10. Chastity.** Members shall live chastity according to their state of life as an integrated love of God, self and neighbour. Married members live faithful and mutual self-giving within marriage; single members live integrity, friendship and responsible boundaries; those freely called to consecrated celibacy shall be faithful to that commitment. All shall reject exploitation, manipulation and secrecy, and shall treat every person with reverence rather than possession.

31. Chastity requires truthfulness, consent, fidelity, appropriate boundaries and freedom from every form of coercion, harassment, grooming or abuse. Members shall cultivate mature friendship and shall not use spiritual authority to create emotional dependency. They shall respect privacy without permitting secrecy to conceal harm. Where relationships become disordered or boundaries fail, members shall seek prompt pastoral and, where appropriate, professional help, always observing safeguarding duties.

32. **11. Obedience.** Obedience is attentive listening to God through the Gospel, prayer, conscience, the Church, this Rule, legitimate authority and the voice of fraternity. It requires members to lay aside self-will, speak truthfully, listen patiently and seek the common good. Ministers shall command nothing contrary to the Gospel, civil law, safeguarding, conscience or reasonable family obligation; no obedience may require unlawful, abusive, degrading or unsafe conduct.

33. A member who receives a direction that appears imprudent shall seek clarification respectfully and may request review. A direction contrary to law, safeguarding, conscience properly formed, professional duty or the welfare of a dependant must not be obeyed. Superiors shall give reasons for significant decisions, keep appropriate records, avoid conflicts of interest and provide access to appeal. Members, for their part, shall not invoke conscience casually to avoid every inconvenience, but shall discern prayerfully, seek counsel and accept legitimate communal obligations.

34. **12. Minority and authority.** Members shall be lesser ones among the people of God, following the humility of Christ and choosing service over privilege, solidarity over social distance and companionship over domination. They shall willingly associate with those whom society overlooks, fears or excludes, and shall resist clericalism, prestige, entitlement and every use of religion to secure influence. Those entrusted with authority shall wash the feet of the fraternity in spirit: consulting, encouraging, correcting with mercy, remaining accountable and seeking the good of the least. No member shall use religious profession, ordination, knowledge, title or office for status, control or personal advantage.

CHAPTER IV FAMILY, WORK AND DISPERSED LIFE

35. *The dispersed Franciscan vocation is ordinarily lived in households, workplaces, neighbourhoods and local churches. These are not interruptions to religious life but its primary field. Members shall resist a division between sacred observance and ordinary responsibility. The quality of their presence at home, reliability at work, use of time, care of health and fidelity to fraternity are essential expressions of profession.*

36. **13. Family.** Marriage and family responsibilities are integral to the Franciscan vocation of members who are spouses, parents or carers. The Order shall not become a rival to the family, nor shall religious activity be used to evade ordinary duties of love, presence and provision. Members shall seek consent and understanding within the household, practise patience in domestic life and recognise care given at home as authentic service of Christ.

37. Members shall plan observance with realistic regard to spouses, partners, children, dependants and shared finances. Major religious commitments affecting the household should be discussed openly. Care work, domestic labour and faithful presence during illness or crisis may properly take precedence over optional gatherings. The fraternity should support, rather than burden, households and shall never presume authority over a non-member spouse or family member.

38. **14. Work.** Honest secular or ministerial work is received as grace and offered to God. Members shall work faithfully and humbly, not extinguishing the spirit of prayer and devotion to which all other things must contribute. They shall act with integrity, diligence, fairness and compassion, refuse exploitative gain, respect the dignity of colleagues and share from the fruits of labour according to their means.

"I worked with my hands, and I still desire to work; and I earnestly desire all brothers to give themselves to honest work."

— Saint Francis, Testament

39. Members shall not despise manual, domestic, professional or unpaid work. They shall observe lawful and ethical standards, honour agreements, safeguard confidential information and resist discrimination, corruption and exploitation. Rest, recreation and Sabbath are necessary to sustainable service and shall not be treated as laziness. Unemployment, retirement or incapacity do not diminish vocation; prayer, neighbourliness, caregiving and patient endurance may become the member's principal work.

40. **15. The home and hospitality.** Each home may become a little place of prayer, hospitality, simplicity and peace. Members shall welcome others according to their means, with prudence, safeguarding and the consent of those with whom they live. They shall never impose religious obligations upon family members who have not undertaken them, but shall witness chiefly through gentleness, service, forgiveness and joy.

41. **16. Fraternity in dispersion.** Members shall maintain active contact with the Order through local, regional or digital fraternities, annual gatherings, correspondence and mutual prayer. They shall not absent themselves through indifference, nor allow another member to disappear unnoticed. Fraternal contact shall include prayer, formation, honest sharing of life, practical assistance and discerning together how the Gospel is to be lived.

42. Every member shall belong to an identifiable circle of pastoral care and shall maintain agreed contact. Fraternities should keep a simple pattern of gathering, attendance and welfare contact, while respecting privacy and data protection. Absence caused by illness, cost, disability, work or family duty shall be met with accommodation. Persistent disengagement should prompt gentle enquiry, not judgement. Members shall notify an appropriate officer when circumstances seriously affect observance, so that support and suitable adaptation can be arranged.

CHAPTER V MISSION, PEACE AND CREATION

43. *Francis sent the brothers among the people to bear peace rather than contention. The mission of the Order is therefore exercised by presence before programme, example before claim, and service before status. Members shall proclaim Christ in ways suited to their vocation, respecting conscience and never exploiting vulnerability. Works of mercy and justice, care for creation and reconciliation belong to one mission because all arise from the Gospel of peace.*

44. **17. Service and mercy.** Every member shall undertake service appropriate to gifts, health and circumstances. Following Francis, members shall not remain at a safe distance from suffering but shall allow the Lord to lead them into merciful encounter. Hidden service, caregiving, listening, intercession and ordinary acts of kindness possess genuine apostolic value and shall not be considered lesser than public ministry.

45. Following the Earlier Rule, members shall recognise two complementary ways of going among others. The first is to avoid quarrels and disputes, to be subject to every human creature for God's sake, and to confess by their manner of life that they are Christians. The second, when they discern that it pleases God, is to proclaim the Word openly. In both forms, mission shall arise from prayer, humility and charity; it shall never rely upon coercion, spiritual superiority or contempt for another person's conscience.

46. **18. The poor and excluded.** Members shall encounter people experiencing poverty, exclusion, illness or suffering as brothers and sisters bearing God-given dignity, never merely as objects of charity. They shall listen before presuming to speak, receive as well as give, and resist attitudes or structures that humiliate or discard. Where possible, service shall include both immediate mercy and patient work for justice.

47. Service shall be shaped with, and not merely for, the people concerned. Members shall learn the realities of their locality and cooperate with competent churches, charities and public services. They shall guard against saviourism, dependency and intrusive curiosity; preserve confidentiality; recognise professional limits; and refer needs responsibly. Advocacy shall be truthful, non-partisan in the proper ecclesial sense, attentive to those directly affected and directed towards the dignity and common good of all.

48. **19. Peace.** Members shall announce peace first by becoming peaceable in heart, speech and conduct. They shall resist hatred, vengeance, dehumanising speech, factionalism and needless conflict, and shall seek reconciliation wherever truth and safety permit. When entering any place or conversation, they should bear the Franciscan greeting of peace in spirit, refusing quarrelsome witness and speaking with humility even amid disagreement.

"As they announce peace with their lips, let them be careful to have it even more within their own hearts."

— Saint Francis, Legend of the Three Companions

49. Peace-making includes disciplined speech, patient listening, refusal of contempt and willingness to repair harm. Members shall be cautious in public controversy and online communication, verify claims before sharing them and avoid language that strips opponents of dignity. Reconciliation does not require a victim to resume unsafe contact, conceal wrongdoing or abandon lawful protection. Where grave

injustice persists, members may engage in peaceful advocacy, protest and non-cooperation consistent with conscience, charity and law.

50. **20. Creation.** Members shall receive creation as gift, kin and summons to praise the Creator. With Saint Francis they shall address the elements and creatures not as possessions without limit but as brothers and sisters that reveal God's goodness and sustain the common household of life. They shall practise gratitude, restraint, responsible consumption and practical ecological care in food, travel, energy, purchasing and waste. Love for creation shall remain inseparable from love for people, especially those who bear the heaviest burdens of environmental harm, and from praise of the Most High to whom every creature ultimately belongs.

51. Each member shall include attainable creation-care commitments within the Personal Rule and review them without rivalry or perfectionism. Fraternities should consider a shared environmental work or practical act of restoration. Ecological choices shall take account of disability, income, location and family need. Members shall connect environmental responsibility with concern for workers, communities and future generations, recognising that care for Sister Earth is inseparable from justice for people made vulnerable by pollution, scarcity and climate disruption.

CHAPTER VI FORMATION, PROFESSION AND PERSEVERANCE

52. *Formation enables a free and mature response to grace. It shall test desire, deepen understanding, cultivate habits and reveal whether the candidate can live fraternity responsibly. Profession then gathers prayer, counsel, service and common life into a stable promise. Because no profession removes human limitation, the Order shall unite high expectation with mercy, accountability with due process, and perseverance with prudent adaptation.*

53. **21. Formation.** Formation is lifelong because conversion is never finished. Members shall study Scripture, the Earlier and Later Rules, the Testament and other Franciscan sources, together with theology, Church life, ethics, safeguarding, peace, justice and care for creation. Study shall lead to prayer and practice rather than pride, and members shall remain teachable, ready to receive wisdom from the learned, the poor, the young, the old and one another.

54. Initial and continuing formation shall include guided reading, prayer, written reflection, practical service, participation in fraternity and regular conversation with a formator. It shall address emotional and spiritual maturity, healthy boundaries, safeguarding, conflict, digital conduct, family responsibilities and the distinction between religious and ordained authority. Progress shall be reviewed honestly and recorded appropriately. Time frames are minimums rather than entitlements: admission to each stage depends upon readiness, freedom, compatibility with the charism and the good of both person and fraternity.

55. **22. Personal Rule.** Each novice and professed member shall keep a Personal Rule of Life adapted to actual circumstances. It shall ordinarily address prayer, Eucharist, Scripture, simplicity, family and work, fasting or penance, fraternity, service, rest, study and care of health. It shall be reviewed regularly with an appointed companion so that it remains demanding enough to foster growth, merciful enough to be sustainable and faithful to this common Rule.

56. The Personal Rule shall state normal practices, reasonable alternatives for disrupted circumstances and a process of review. Commitments should be specific enough to guide conduct without becoming a source of anxiety or false precision. Material changes in marriage, employment, health, caring duty, residence or ministry shall prompt revision in consultation with the appointed companion. The common Rule remains normative; the Personal Rule applies it and may not remove its essential requirements without proper dispensation.

57. **23. Profession.** Temporary and perpetual profession are free commitments to live the Holy Gospel according to this Rule in obedience, without anything of one's own, and in chastity according to each member's state of life. Within the dispersed character of the Order, these promises are expressed through prayer, fraternity, simplicity, responsible stewardship, minority and service. Profession is not a claim to perfection but a public self-offering and a promise to persevere in conversion with the help of divine grace and the fraternity. Members shall renew the spirit of their profession frequently and shall neither seek privileges from it nor judge those whose vocation differs from their own.

58. Before profession, the candidate shall understand the promises, the proper law of the Order, the forms of authority and accountability, the provision for departure and the continuing responsibilities of family and civil life. The fraternity shall discern without haste and shall neither reward conformity of personality nor

overlook serious concerns from a desire to increase numbers. Profession should be received publicly in prayer, recorded accurately and accompanied by continuing pastoral care. Anniversaries may be occasions for thanksgiving, examination and renewal.

59. **24. Perseverance and correction.** Members shall persevere in the promised life with patience, guarding against discouragement, spiritual pride and hardness of heart. Failure shall be met first with truth, repentance, mercy, practical amendment and renewed effort. Fraternal correction shall be private where possible, proportionate and directed towards restoration; discipline, where required, shall protect persons, observe due process and never become humiliation or revenge.

"What you hold, may you always hold. What you do, may you always do and never abandon."

— Saint Clare, Second Letter to Agnes of Prague

60. Members shall guard the joy of the Gospel, not as constant cheerfulness but as grateful confidence that every good comes from God. In trial they shall resist bitterness, self-pity and the temptation to abandon fraternity. They shall give thanks for grace received through others, rejoice in the good done by another, and return all praise to God. Joy, humility and gratitude shall be signs that perseverance is becoming evangelical rather than merely stubborn.

61. Perseverance does not mean remaining unchanged or concealing difficulty. Members shall ask for help early and receive appropriate spiritual, medical, psychological or safeguarding support. The fraternity should distinguish temporary weakness, persistent neglect and serious misconduct, responding proportionately. Restoration requires acknowledgement of harm, protection of those affected, changed behaviour and reasonable accountability; forgiveness must never be demanded as a substitute for justice. Where continued membership is no longer truthful or safe, leave, release or dismissal may be pursued according to the Constitutions without denying the person's dignity.

CONCLUSION OF THE RULE

62. Let the brothers and sisters remember that the Lord has called them together and entrusted them with this form of Gospel life. Let them love one another in deed, be gentle with the burdened, courageous before injustice, reverent in worship, faithful in prayer, honest in work, simple in possessions, careful in speech and joyful in service. Let them begin again each day in penance and gratitude; go among others without quarrelling or claiming superiority; honour the Body of Christ, the words of Scripture and the dignity of every person; and receive the whole creation as a song of praise. Let every home become a place of prayer, every table a place of welcome, every workplace a field of witness, every wound an invitation to mercy and every encounter an opportunity to recognise and serve Christ.

Peace and all good.



THE CONSTITUTIONS

of the Order of Saints Francis and Clare

PREAMBLE

63. These Constitutions give practical and juridical expression to the Rule. They regulate membership, formation, profession, government, fraternity, safeguarding, individual responsibility for financing vocation and administration. They shall be interpreted according to the Gospel, the Franciscan spirit, charity, responsible freedom, the Rule and the lawful discipline of the Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church.

ARTICLE I NAME, NATURE AND CHARISM

64. **1.1 Name.** The community is the Order of Saints Francis and Clare and may use the abbreviation OSFC.

65. **1.2 Nature.** OSFC is a Franciscan religious order of the Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church, possessing its own Rule, Constitutions, government, formation, customs, registers and forms of profession.

66. **1.3 Patrons.** Saint Francis and Saint Clare are the principal patrons.

67. **1.5 Ecclesial character and inclusion.** OSFC shares the inclusive, progressive and liberal Catholic character of the LCAC, its sacramental life and Apostolic Succession. Admission, formation, profession, office and participation shall be open without discrimination unrelated to genuine suitability, vocation, safeguarding or the essential requirements of the Rule.

68. **1.6 Suitability and dignity.** Radical inclusion does not remove standards. Every person shall be treated with dignity, while suitability for profession or office shall be discerned by consistent criteria of emotional and human maturity, spiritual accountability, pastoral and psychological safety, and demonstrated practical fruit. Title, ordination, friendship, seniority, wealth or personal influence shall never substitute for suitability.

69. **1.4 Charism.** The charism is to follow Jesus Christ according to the Holy Gospel through prayer, simplicity, humility, minority, fraternity, reconciliation, service and reverence for creation.

ARTICLE II PROPER LAW

70. **2.1 Order of norms.** The Order is governed by applicable LCAC Canon Law, the Rule, these Constitutions, the Customary and Directory, and lawful decisions of the General Chapter.

71. **2.2 Rule and Constitutions.** The Rule expresses the spiritual form of life; the Constitutions regulate its practical implementation.

72. **2.3 Subsidiary norms.** The General Chapter may adopt formation, safeguarding, liturgical and electoral regulations consistent with the Rule and Constitutions.

73. **2.4 Binding standards.** All members, officers, fraternities and ministries of OSFC are bound by applicable civil law, the LCAC Canons and Code of Conduct, safeguarding requirements, lawful decrees of competent LCAC authority, and the proper law of the Order. No custom, private agreement or local practice may excuse non-compliance.

74. **2.5 Interpretation and conflict.** These Constitutions shall be interpreted in favour of the Gospel, Franciscan minority, human dignity, pastoral safety, natural justice and the common good. Where norms conflict, the higher lawful norm prevails. Questions of interpretation shall first be considered by the Minister General and Council and, where they concern LCAC authority, doctrine, safeguarding or discipline, referred to the competent LCAC authority.

ARTICLE III MEMBERSHIP

75. **3.1 Stages.** The stages are Inquirer, Postulant, Novice, Temporary Profession and Perpetual Profession.

76. **3.2 Associates.** Companions or Associates may share the spirituality and works of OSFC without religious profession.

77. **3.3 Equality.** The Order is one family of friars and sisters. No separate class of religious dignity arises from ordination, gender or marital status.

78. **3.4 Rights of members.** Every member has the right to receive the Rule and proper law, participate according to status, receive appropriate formation and pastoral care, be heard before adverse decisions, make a complaint without retaliation, have personal information handled responsibly, and appeal as provided by these Constitutions.

79. **3.5 Duties of members.** Every member shall live the Rule honestly, maintain contact with the fraternity, complete required formation, observe safeguarding and confidentiality, disclose relevant conflicts or restrictions, cooperate with lawful oversight, protect the reputation of the Church and Order, and report serious risk, abuse or misconduct through the proper channels.

ARTICLE IV LAY, ORDAINED, MARRIED AND SINGLE MEMBERS

80. **4.1 Ordained members.** Ordination confers sacramental responsibilities but does not create a higher grade of OSFC membership. Religious government and episcopal jurisdiction shall remain properly distinguished. In accordance with the LCAC model of clergy service, every LCAC cleric within the Order serves as a volunteer, non-stipendiary minister, not as an employee of the LCAC or OSFC under the intended ecclesiastical arrangement. Ordination, licensing, religious profession and appointment to religious office do not of themselves constitute a contract of employment or confer entitlement to a salary or stipend. This statement describes the intended arrangement; any employment or worker status and

statutory rights shall be determined by applicable civil law and the actual circumstances, not by designation alone.

81. **4.2 Marriage.** Marriage and profession are compatible vocations. The care of spouse, children and dependants is integral to the member's Franciscan life.

82. **4.3 Single life.** Single members live chastity appropriate to their state and remain free to discern marriage unless they have separately and freely undertaken consecrated celibacy.

83. **4.4 Offices.** Except where an office intrinsically requires ordination, suitable lay or ordained perpetually professed members may hold office.

84. **4.5 Distinction of authority.** Religious profession does not confer Holy Orders, sacramental faculties, civil employment, episcopal jurisdiction or authority over a member's spouse, family, employer or private property. Ordination does not by itself confer religious office. Every ministry shall operate only within the authority actually granted.

ARTICLE V ADMISSION AND FORMATION

85. **5.1 Admission.** Candidates shall be baptised Christians of sincere faith, appropriate maturity and willingness to live the Rule, undertake formation and comply with safeguarding requirements.

86. **5.2 Postulancy.** Postulancy ordinarily lasts six to twelve months and introduces Franciscan spirituality, prayer, fraternity, LCAC life, safeguarding and discernment.

87. **5.3 Novitiate.** The novitiate ordinarily lasts at least twelve months and provides systematic formation in Scripture, Franciscan sources, prayer, evangelical counsels, fraternity, peace, creation care, ecclesiology, ethics and safeguarding.

88. **5.4 Formation companion.** Each postulant and novice should have an appointed formator, Guardian or Formation Companion.

89. **5.5 Personal Rule.** During the novitiate the candidate develops a Personal Rule of Life adapted to actual circumstances.

90. **5.6 Application and references.** An applicant shall provide the information reasonably required to discern vocation and safety, including identity, baptismal status, ecclesial history, relevant references, criminal-record or safeguarding checks where required, and candid disclosure of any restriction, investigation or circumstance materially affecting suitability. Information shall be proportionate, confidential and lawfully handled.

91. **5.7 Four pillars of formation.** Formation and review shall address: emotional and human maturity, including self-awareness and healthy conflict; spiritual accountability, including prayer and servant leadership; pastoral and psychological safety, including boundaries and use of power; and practical fruit, shown through reliable service. Serious narcissistic, exploitative, coercive, deceptive or persistently volatile conduct is incompatible with admission or advancement while it remains unaddressed.

92. **5.8 Assessment and review.** Admission to each stage requires a written recommendation from the formator and a reasoned decision by the competent authority. The candidate shall receive constructive notice of areas requiring growth.

A stage may be extended, paused or ended where readiness is not established; completion of a minimum period creates no entitlement to profession.

ARTICLE VI PROFESSION

93. **6.1 Temporary profession.** After satisfactory novitiate a candidate may make temporary profession, ordinarily for one year at a time.

94. **6.2 Perpetual profession.** Perpetual profession is a lifelong commitment and requires freedom, maturity, completed formation, faithful fraternity and an approved Personal Rule.

95. **6.3 Reception.** Profession is normally received by the Minister General or a duly authorised delegate and entered in the Register of Professions.

96. **6.4 Freedom.** No person shall be pressured to renew temporary profession or proceed to perpetual profession.

97. **6.5 Conditions for valid profession.** Profession requires adequate age and capacity, freedom from coercion, completion of the required formation, informed assent to the Rule and proper law, acceptance by competent authority, and use of the approved rite before appropriate witnesses. The act and its date shall be recorded promptly.

ARTICLE VII GENERAL CHAPTER

98. **7.1 Nature.** The General Chapter is the principal deliberative and elective assembly of OSFC, subject to lawful LCAC ecclesiastical authority.

99. **7.2 Voice and vote.** Perpetually professed members ordinarily possess voice and vote. Participation may be in person or by an authorised electronic means.

100. **7.3 Competence.** The Chapter elects the Minister General, receives reports, reviews formation, determines major policy, considers amendments and discerns the future direction of the Order.

101. **7.4 Decisions.** Prayer, consultation and consensus are preferred; formal voting is used when needed.

102. **7.5 Convocation and notice.** An ordinary General Chapter shall be held at intervals determined by proper law and at least once during each term of the Minister General. Reasonable written notice shall state the date, means of participation, agenda, elections and proposed constitutional amendments. An extraordinary Chapter may be convoked for urgent grave business.

103. **7.6 Quorum and voting.** Unless a higher threshold is specified, quorum shall be a majority of those entitled to vote and decisions shall be by a majority of votes cast. Constitutional amendment, dissolution, removal from elected office and other reserved matters require the stated qualified majority. Electronic participation and secure electronic voting are valid when identity, fairness and an adequate record are maintained.

ARTICLE VIII MINISTER GENERAL AND COUNCIL

104. **8.1 Minister General.** The Minister General is the principal religious superior and servant of the fraternity, guardian of the Rule and representative of the Order.

105. **8.2 Term.** The Minister General serves for three years and may be re-elected once consecutively.

106. **8.3 Council.** The General Council ordinarily includes the Minister General, Deputy Minister General, Secretary, Director of Formation and additional Councillors as determined by Chapter.

107. **8.4 Collegiality.** Important decisions affecting the whole Order should ordinarily be made collegially with the Council.

108. **8.5 Guardians.** Local or regional fraternities may have Guardians or Local Ministers who exercise pastoral and administrative service, not unrestricted authority.

109. **8.6 Duties of office-holders.** Office-holders act as servants of the Order. They shall pray, consult, keep proper records, safeguard confidential information, communicate decisions, remain within delegated authority, avoid favouritism and ensure that pastoral, safeguarding and legal matters are referred to competent persons.

110. **8.7 Conflicts, recusal and accountability.** A person with a personal, financial, familial, pastoral or other material conflict shall disclose it and withdraw from decision-making where impartiality could reasonably be questioned. The Council may require recusal. No person shall determine a complaint or appeal concerning their own conduct or a matter in which they were substantially involved.

ARTICLE IX FRATERNITY AND PRAYER

111. **9.1 Dispersed character.** Common residence is not required. Members may belong to local, regional, national or digital fraternities.

112. **9.2 Meetings.** Fraternities gather regularly for prayer, formation, fellowship, mutual support and service.

113. **9.3 Prayer.** Morning and Evening Prayer, regular Eucharistic participation, Scripture, contemplation and annual retreat form the ordinary spiritual rhythm, adapted by the Personal Rule.

114. **9.4 Pastoral care and attendance.** Each member shall belong to an identifiable fraternity or pastoral-care arrangement. Absence caused by health, disability, cost, work or family duty shall be accommodated. Persistent unexplained absence shall prompt discreet welfare contact. Participation records shall be minimal and used for pastoral and administrative purposes only.

ARTICLE X EVANGELICAL COUNSELS AND PROPERTY

115. **10.1 Simplicity.** Members normally retain personal property and income while living simply, generously and responsibly.

116. **10.2 Family provision.** Members shall make prudent provision for family, housing, health, disability needs and old age.

117. **10.3 Individual responsibility.** Each individual member is expected to finance his or her own vocation, including personal living costs and the costs of formation, habit, books, travel, retreats and ministry, according to actual circumstances and without neglecting family responsibilities.

118. **10.4 Personal provision.** All members of the Order, ordained and lay alike, serve on a voluntary, unpaid and non-stipendiary basis. Each member is responsible for supporting himself or herself from his or her own lawful income and financial resources and for financing his or her own vocation. Membership and profession do not create an entitlement to financial maintenance, a stipend, reimbursement or payment of personal expenses by the Order. Members remain responsible for their own income, expenditure and financial commitments. This voluntary arrangement applies equally to religious office, formation and authorised ministry; the Order does not undertake to employ or financially maintain its members. The civil-law safeguard in paragraph 80 applies equally to ordained and lay members. Nothing in this provision excludes any statutory right or obligation arising under applicable civil law.

119. **10.5 Personal costs and sacramental ministry.** Members shall arrange and pay directly for the goods and services needed for their vocation. The Order shall not impose compulsory oblations upon members. No Sacrament, pastoral care or admission decision shall be made conditional upon payment.

120. **10.6 Sustainable observance.** Members shall plan vocational commitments realistically within their means. Where cost prevents participation in a particular activity, an appropriate low-cost or no-cost alternative should be agreed, consistent with the Rule and family responsibilities. Such accommodation does not transfer responsibility for financing the member's vocation to the Order.

ARTICLE XI APOSTOLATE AND CONDUCT

121. **11.1 Apostolate.** Members undertake suitable works of mercy, ministry, caregiving, intercession, peace-making or creation care according to capacity.

122. **11.2 Public witness.** Members shall distinguish personal views from official OSFC positions and shall not claim authority to speak for the Order without authorisation.

123. **11.3 Fraternal conduct.** Members shall avoid gossip, humiliation and factionalism and seek to address ordinary disagreements directly and charitably.

124. **11.4 Pastoral boundaries and use of power.** Members shall recognise the imbalance of power in pastoral, formational and supervisory relationships. They shall not exploit another person for emotional, spiritual, financial or personal benefit; create dependency; seek gifts or favours improperly; or use religious language, office, threats, secrecy or claims of obedience to control another person. Physical contact shall be appropriate, explained and consensual.

125. **11.5 Confidentiality and information.** Pastoral information shall be kept confidential except where disclosure is required by law, safeguarding, immediate safety or proper ecclesiastical process. The sacramental seal, where applicable to an authorised cleric, shall be governed by LCAC Canon Law. Members shall explain the limits of ordinary pastoral confidentiality and keep notes only where necessary, securely and factually.

126. **11.6 Public communication and digital conduct.** No member may speak officially for OSFC or the LCAC without authorisation. Personal public statements shall be clearly identified as such and, where confusion is reasonably possible, accompanied by an appropriate disclaimer. Members shall communicate truthfully and peaceably, respect privacy and copyright, protect confidential information,

avoid harassment and dehumanising speech, and never use OSFC platforms for unauthorised fundraising or personal commercial gain.

ARTICLE XII SAFEGUARDING AND DISCIPLINE

127. **12.1 Safeguarding.** All members shall observe applicable civil law, LCAC requirements and OSFC safeguarding policies. Religious obedience may never be used to suppress legitimate safeguarding action.

128. **12.2 Discipline.** Formal discipline requires clear notice, reasonable opportunity to respond, impartial consideration, proportionate action, a reasoned decision and a right of appeal.

129. **12.3 Protective measures.** Temporary restrictions may be imposed when necessary to protect others while a serious matter is investigated; they do not themselves determine guilt.

130. **12.4 Reporting and referral.** A concern involving a child, vulnerable adult, abuse, grooming, coercion, serious risk, criminal conduct or immediate danger shall be reported without delay to the OSFC Safeguarding Lead, the competent LCAC authority and civil authorities where law or safety requires. Internal procedure shall never delay emergency action or lawful reporting. Retaliation against a person who raises a concern in good faith is prohibited.

131. **12.5 Complaints and triage.** Complaints may be made in writing or, where necessary, received orally and recorded. They shall be acknowledged, risk-assessed and assigned promptly. A matter may be directed to pastoral resolution, formal investigation, safeguarding procedure, independent review of alleged financial misconduct, or competent LCAC or civil authority. Such review concerns alleged misconduct, not the administration of funds held by the Order, and does not create responsibility for financing a member's vocation. Mediation shall not be used where there is alleged abuse, coercion, serious power imbalance or risk of further harm.

132. **12.6 Investigation and determination.** A formal investigation shall be impartial, proportionate and appropriately confidential. The respondent shall receive sufficient particulars and reasonable opportunity to answer, subject to protective needs and lawful restrictions. Relevant evidence shall be considered fairly. The decision shall state findings, reasons, action and appeal rights. The standard of proof for internal disciplinary findings is the balance of probabilities unless higher law requires otherwise.

133. **12.7 Outcomes and appeal.** Outcomes may include no further action, advice, formation, supervision, apology, restorative steps, warning, restriction, suspension from office or ministry, removal from office, recommendation concerning membership, or referral to LCAC authority. An appeal must identify material procedural error, unreasonable finding, disproportionate outcome or significant new evidence, and shall be determined by a person or panel not previously responsible for the decision.

ARTICLE XIII LEAVE, DEPARTURE AND DISMISSAL

134. **13.1 Leave.** A member may request temporary leave for illness, bereavement, family responsibility, work, caring duties or vocational discernment.

135. **13.2 Departure.** A temporarily professed member may decline renewal. A perpetually professed member seeking release shall petition the Minister General and any applicable LCAC requirements shall be observed.

136. **13.3 Dismissal.** Dismissal is reserved for sufficiently grave cause and shall follow due process and provide a right of appeal.

137. **13.4 Pastoral and administrative consequences.** Leave, departure, release or dismissal shall be recorded clearly, including the effect upon office, representation, habit, insignia, access to records and OSFC platforms. Departure from the Order does not of itself alter Holy Orders or LCAC faculties, which belong to the competent ecclesiastical authority. The Order shall communicate only what is necessary, lawful and pastorally responsible.

ARTICLE XIV REGISTERS

138. **14.1 Registers.** OSFC shall maintain secure registers of postulants, novices, temporary professions, perpetual professions, offices, transfers, releases, departures, dismissals and deceased members.

139. **14.2 Privacy.** Access to personal records shall be limited to proper pastoral, canonical, safeguarding or administrative purposes.

140. **14.3 Record standards and retention.** Records shall be accurate, dated, attributable, secure and retained for a period proportionate to canonical, safeguarding, legal and administrative need. Safeguarding and disciplinary records shall not be destroyed merely because a person departs. Access, correction, sharing and disposal shall comply with applicable data-protection law and LCAC policy.

ARTICLE XV AMENDMENT AND DISSOLUTION

141. **15.1 Amendment.** Constitutional amendments require appropriate notice and a two-thirds majority at a duly constituted General Chapter, together with any ecclesiastical approval required by LCAC law.

142. **15.2 Dissolution.** Lawful dissolution shall be recorded and communicated to members and the competent LCAC authority, with appropriate arrangements for the custody of official records and the pastoral consequences for members.

143. **15.3 Consultation and approval.** Proposed amendments shall be circulated with reasons and sufficient time for prayerful consideration. No text marked draft or proposed shall bind until lawfully adopted and, where required, approved and promulgated by competent LCAC authority. Amendments shall be dated, version-controlled and deposited with the official records.

ARTICLE XVI PROMULGATION

144. **16.1 Effect.** These Constitutions, together with the Rule, constitute the proper law governing OSFC religious life, subject to the lawful authority and Canon Law of the Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church.

145. **16.2 Spirit.** They shall be administered as instruments of Gospel life, never as substitutes for charity, mercy, justice or pastoral wisdom.

146. **16.3 Annual affirmation and review.** Office-holders and those carrying authorised pastoral, formational or representative responsibilities shall affirm

compliance with the Rule, these Constitutions, the LCAC Code of Conduct and safeguarding requirements at appointment and thereafter as directed. The Council shall review implementation annually and report material risks, policy gaps and recommended amendments to the General Chapter and competent LCAC authority.



THE CUSTOMARY

Practical customs for the common life of OSFC friars and sisters

FOREWORD

147. The Customary describes how the Rule and Constitutions are ordinarily embodied in daily life. It is a school of Gospel freedom rather than a catalogue of burdens, and it gives the fraternity a recognisable common rhythm without demanding uniform circumstances. Because OSFC is principally dispersed, every custom shall be interpreted with evangelical seriousness, Franciscan simplicity, pastoral wisdom and due regard for health, disability, marriage, family, employment, caring duties, poverty and local opportunity. The Rule remains the spiritual norm, the Constitutions the juridical norm, and the Customary their ordinary practical expression.

148. *The Customary exists to serve the Franciscan vocation; the Franciscan vocation does not exist to serve the Customary.*

149. **Use and adaptation.** No member should multiply observances beyond what can be lived faithfully, peacefully and without neglect of another vocation. A temporary adaptation made for illness, crisis, family care, work or travel does not diminish profession. Where an essential practice is persistently impossible, the member should review the Personal Rule with the appointed companion and agree a sustainable equivalent.

PART I THE FRANCISCAN DAY

150. **Beginning the day.** Members should begin with a conscious offering to God before becoming absorbed in ordinary activity. Morning Prayer should ordinarily be prayed each day.

151. **Adapted Office.** Where illness, shift work, childcare or serious responsibility prevents the full Office, a shorter form may include an invocation, Psalm, Scripture, intercession and the Lord's Prayer.

152. **During the day.** Brief recollection, thanksgiving, the Jesus Prayer, the Angelus or silent intercession may be used as circumstances allow.

153. **Evening.** Evening Prayer and a brief examination of the day should ordinarily conclude the active day. Compline or a simple commendation to God may be used before sleep.

154. **Examination and thanksgiving.** The evening review should begin with thanksgiving, then consider where grace was received, where love was refused, whether anyone was harmed, and what amendment or reconciliation is needed. It

should end in trust rather than self-accusation. Members should seek prompt repair when words, neglect or conduct have caused harm.

155. Silence and availability. Members should protect at least a brief daily period free from messages, media and unnecessary speech. Silence is not withdrawal from responsibility but attention to God and neighbour. Phones and devices should ordinarily be silenced during prayer, fraternity meetings, pastoral conversation and meals shared as intentional hospitality.

PART II THE FRANCISCAN WEEK

156. Sunday. Sunday Eucharist should ordinarily stand at the centre of the sacramental week.

157. Friday. Friday should normally retain a penitential character through simplicity in food, restraint, prayer, almsgiving, service or another practice stated in the Personal Rule.

158. Health. Fasting shall never be practised in a way that damages health. Members for whom dietary fasting is unsuitable should choose another penitential practice.

159. Weekly review and Sabbath. Once each week members should review the balance of prayer, family, work, rest, service and fraternity. A reasonable period of Sabbath rest should be protected from avoidable work and constant digital activity. Those whose employment prevents Sunday rest should identify another period for worship, renewal, family presence and recreation.

160. Intercession for the fraternity. Each member should keep the Order, its ministers, those in formation, the sick, the departed and persons commended for prayer within the weekly intercessions. Prayer lists containing sensitive information shall be shared only with consent or in a suitably general form.

PART III SACRAMENTAL AND DEVOTIONAL LIFE

161. Reconciliation. Regular examination of conscience, sacramental reconciliation where available, and spiritual direction or pastoral conversation are encouraged without scrupulosity.

162. Franciscan devotions. Members may use the Franciscan Crown, the San Damiano Cross, Stations of the Cross, the Canticle of the Creatures, prayers of Francis and Clare, Nativity devotions and prayers for peace and creation.

163. Scripture. Regular reading of the Gospels is expected. Members should ask not only what the Gospel means, but how it is to be lived today.

164. Eucharistic preparation and thanksgiving. Members should prepare for the Eucharist by recollection, reconciliation where needed and attention to the readings. After Communion they should allow a period of thanksgiving and ask how Christ's self-giving is to be continued through service. Those unable to receive sacramentally should remain united through prayer, Scripture and spiritual communion according to LCAC practice.

165. Holy Scripture and sacred things. Bibles, liturgical books, vessels, vesture and places reserved for worship shall be treated with reverence and kept in good order. Damaged sacred items should be repaired or disposed of respectfully. No member may reserve the Blessed Sacrament, celebrate a Sacrament or exercise liturgical ministry without the authority and faculties required by LCAC law.

PART IV THE HOME AS FRIARY

166. Prayer place. Where practicable, members may create a simple place for prayer containing a cross, Bible, candle, sacred image, Rule and Office.

167. Family home. The home of a married member remains first a family home. Spouses and children who are not members shall not be expected to live as if they had entered the Order.

168. Hospitality. Hospitality may be expressed through meals, conversation, practical assistance, prayer, befriending or welcome, always with proper safeguarding and family consent.

169. Boundaries of hospitality. Hospitality shall never place a spouse, child, dependant, guest or member at avoidable risk. Overnight accommodation, transport of children or vulnerable adults, and private pastoral meetings in the home shall follow LCAC safeguarding requirements. Members should avoid creating dependency, making promises beyond their capacity or allowing the home to become an unauthorised institution or ministry base.

170. Household consent and privacy. Religious symbols, meetings, visiting members and online broadcasting from a shared home should be arranged with the knowledge and reasonable consent of the household. Photographs, addresses and details of family life shall not be published as part of OSFC activity without appropriate permission.

PART V SIMPLICITY AND POSSESSIONS

171. Poverty in dispersion. Members normally retain income and personal property. The guiding question is not simply what one owns, but whether possessions dominate the heart.

172. Provision. Reasonable provision for accommodation, family, healthcare, transport, education, disability needs and retirement is compatible with Franciscan simplicity.

173. Giving. Generosity should be proportionate to actual means and may include money, time, skills, hospitality, goods, service and prayer.

174. Annual simplicity review. At least annually, members should review possessions, subscriptions, debts, savings, investments, charitable giving, energy use and patterns of consumption. The purpose is freedom and gratitude, not comparison. Items no longer needed should be shared, sold responsibly, recycled or disposed of appropriately; financial decisions affecting a household remain subject to family duties and lawful ownership.

175. Borrowing and gifts. Members shall not borrow from, lend money to, solicit gifts from or enter business arrangements with persons to whom they minister unless the arrangement is ordinary, transparent and free from pastoral influence. Substantial gifts connected with ministry should be declined or referred for independent consideration. Personal need shall not be concealed, but assistance should be sought through safe and accountable channels.

PART VI WORK AND SECULAR LIFE

176. Work. Secular and ministerial work form part of the vocation. Members should be honest, dependable, fair, compassionate and diligent. All ordained and lay members undertake their service, ministry and religious office within OSFC as volunteers on an unpaid, non-stipendiary basis and rely upon their own lawful income and financial resources for personal support and vocational costs, as provided in paragraph 118. Members should plan ministry realistically alongside their livelihood, family duties, health and rest. This voluntary character does not remove requirements for lawful authorisation, safeguarding, formation or accountability, and does not alter the terms or rights of any separate secular employment.

177. Witness. Members shall not use OSFC membership to seek status or advantage at work. The workplace may itself become a field of quiet Christian presence.

178. Integrity and conflicts. Members shall honour professional standards, contracts, confidentiality and lawful management. They should disclose to the relevant employer or OSFC officer any conflict between religious office and employment. OSFC titles, contacts, mailing lists, platforms or insignia shall not be used to obtain customers, influence, preferential treatment or private financial gain.

179. Rest and wellbeing. Work and ministry shall be ordered so that chronic overwork is not praised as holiness. Members should take reasonable leave, maintain healthcare, seek professional assistance when needed and inform an appropriate officer where exhaustion, illness or distress materially affects ministry or observance. The fraternity should help members recognise limits before crisis occurs.

PART VII FRATERNITY

180. Meeting pattern. An ordinary fraternity meeting may include welcome, opening prayer, Scripture, Franciscan formation, discussion, apostolic review, necessary business, intercessions and fellowship.

181. Digital fraternity. Online gatherings are a genuine means of sustaining common life where geography prevents frequent physical meeting.

182. Conduct. Speak to the person rather than about the person. This does not prevent safeguarding reports, formal complaints or necessary disclosure to competent authorities.

183. Titles. Professed members are fundamentally brothers and sisters. Ecclesiastical titles may be used appropriately but must not create an artificial hierarchy within fraternity.

184. Mutual care. Members should make reasonable needs known without shame and respond to one another with Clarean tenderness. A fraternity should appoint or identify a person responsible for welfare contact, especially for isolated, elderly, ill or newly professed members. Practical support may include transport, meals, accompaniment, technology assistance, prayer and referral to competent services. This fraternal care does not create an entitlement to financial maintenance, reimbursement or payment of personal expenses by the Order; each ordained or lay member remains responsible for personal support and vocational costs under paragraphs 117–120.

185. Ordinary disagreement. Where safe and appropriate, a member should address a minor grievance directly, privately and promptly, describing conduct and its effect without accusation. If unresolved, the Guardian may facilitate a conversation. Mediation is voluntary and shall not be used for alleged abuse, coercion, serious misconduct, safeguarding concerns or a material power imbalance.

186. Fraternity business. Agendas should distinguish prayer, formation, pastoral sharing and formal business. Decisions shall be recorded with responsible persons and review dates, while confidential pastoral detail is omitted from ordinary minutes. A member with a conflict of interest shall declare it and withdraw where required. Meetings should end with a clear summary of agreed actions.

PART VIII HABIT AND INSIGNIA

187. Principle. Franciscan dress is a sign of simplicity, fraternity and witness, never superiority.

188. Full habit. The approved full habit may consist of a simple brown or earth-toned tunic, approved hood or capuche, Franciscan cord, simple footwear and Tau or OSFC cross. Sisters may wear an approved veil optionally; a veil is not required merely by profession. Given the small and dispersed nature of the Order, each member is expected to purchase his or her own approved habit and any related items required for the stage being entered, at personal expense, and have them ready in good time for clothing, reception into the novitiate or profession, as applicable. The member shall confirm the required items and approved design with the formator or competent superior before purchasing, allowing sufficient time for delivery and fitting. Ceremonial reception of a habit or insignia does not mean that the Order supplies or pays for it. Any difficulty in obtaining the required items should be raised in advance so that a simple, affordable arrangement may be agreed in accordance with paragraphs 117–120.

189. Cord. Where three knots are used they may signify Simplicity, Chastity according to State of Life, and Obedience.

190. Simplified dress. For everyday ministry, approved alternatives may include an OSFC shirt, clerical shirt where appropriate, Tau cross, cord, lapel badge or other approved insignia.

191. Use. The habit may appropriately be worn at Chapters, retreats, professions, Franciscan feasts, liturgies, pilgrimages, funerals, authorised ministry and suitable public service, subject to safety and professional requirements.

192. Custody and restraint. Habit and insignia remain signs of vocation and shall be clean, simple and used with dignity. They shall not be worn to imply faculties, office, endorsement or authority that the member does not possess. A member subject to restriction, leave or investigation shall follow any direction concerning their use. Alterations, decorations or commercial reproductions require approval.

193. Safety and context. Habit shall not be worn where it creates a foreseeable safety risk, breaches lawful workplace requirements, compromises safeguarding, or confuses the wearer with an authorised chaplain, cleric or public officer. Simpler insignia may be used when full habit would distract from service or place another person under pressure.

PART IX FORMATION CUSTOMS

194. Postulant. Postulants ordinarily wear no habit but may receive an approved small cross or badge.

195. Novice. At reception into the novitiate, a novice may receive the Rule, Constitutions, Customary, approved novice insignia and, if desired, a religious name. The member shall obtain any required habit and insignia beforehand at personal expense under paragraph 188; their ceremonial reception does not mean that the Order supplies or pays for them.

196. Temporary profession. Temporary profession normally includes reception of the insignia proper to professed members.

197. Perpetual profession. Perpetual profession should normally be celebrated in the Eucharist and in the presence of the fraternity where reasonably possible.

198. Formation file and reviews. Each stage should have agreed learning outcomes, regular meetings and a written review recording strengths, evidence of growth, concerns, accommodations and the recommendation made. The candidate should ordinarily see and discuss the review. Sensitive information shall be restricted to those with a proper role and retained in accordance with the Constitutions.

199. Formation relationship. A formator accompanies discernment but shall not demand disclosure beyond what is relevant, practise therapy without qualification, create dependency or promise advancement. Significant concerns shall be addressed honestly and promptly. Where the formator also holds another role that creates conflict, a separate reviewer should be appointed.

200. Readiness for profession. Discernment should consider sustained prayer, honest self-knowledge, capacity for fraternity, responsible boundaries, acceptance of correction, family and work stability, reliable service, financial realism and freedom from coercion. Charisma, theological knowledge, ordination or enthusiasm shall not compensate for serious deficits in safety, truthfulness or accountability.

PART X FEASTS AND OBSERVANCES

201. Principal feasts. OSFC gives particular honour to Saint Francis of Assisi and Saint Clare of Assisi and may observe the Stigmata of Saint Francis, Our Lady of the Angels of the Portiuncula, the Transitus and suitable commemorations of the Franciscan family, harmonised with the authorised LCAC calendar.

202. Transitus. The Transitus may include subdued lighting, Scripture, a reading concerning the death of Francis, silence, psalmody, prayers for departed Franciscans and renewal of commitment. Dispersed members may participate online.

203. Calendar and local observance. The Secretary or another appointed member should publish the annual OSFC calendar in harmony with the authorised LCAC calendar. Fraternities may add local Franciscan commemorations provided they do not displace principal ecclesial observances. Feasts should combine worship, formation, fraternity and, where possible, an act of generosity or service.

PART XI RETREAT, STUDY AND REVIEW

204. Annual retreat. Every professed member should seek an annual retreat, residential, local, online, individually directed or at home. Financial hardship should not bar observance: a suitable low-cost or no-cost form should be chosen under paragraph 120. Any costs remain the member's responsibility under paragraphs 117–118; this provision does not require the Order to fund a retreat.

205. Study. Continuing formation should include Scripture, Franciscan sources, theology, Church history, pastoral practice, safeguarding, justice, peace and creation care.

206. Annual review. Each professed member should review prayer, Gospel living, simplicity, relationships, fraternity, service, reconciliation, formation, creation care and wellbeing with an appropriate companion or Guardian.

PART XII THE PERSONAL RULE AND ANNUAL COVENANT

207. Content. The Personal Rule should ordinarily state achievable commitments for daily and weekly prayer, Eucharist, Scripture, penance, simplicity, family, work, rest, fraternity, service, study, creation care, health and digital restraint. It should name reasonable alternatives for disrupted circumstances and identify the person with whom it will be reviewed.

208. Review. The Personal Rule shall be reviewed at least annually and after a material change of health, household, employment, ministry or caring responsibility. Review should ask what bears evangelical fruit, what has become unrealistic, what is being avoided and what new grace is inviting. Revision is not failure; concealment and chronic imprudence are greater concerns than honest adaptation.

209. Annual covenant. At the annual review, a professed member may sign a short covenant affirming continued adherence to the Rule, Constitutions, Customary, LCAC Code of Conduct and safeguarding requirements, noting agreed priorities for the coming year. This is a pastoral and accountability instrument, not a renewal of perpetual profession.

PART XIII DIGITAL LIFE AND PUBLIC COMMUNICATION

210. Conduct online. Truthfulness, courtesy, restraint, privacy and peace-making apply online. Members should resist the need to answer every provocation.

211. Representation. Members shall clearly distinguish personal opinions from positions formally adopted by OSFC.

212. Official accounts and access. OSFC websites, social channels, mailing lists and shared drives shall have named administrators, secure passwords, appropriate multi-factor authentication and an agreed succession arrangement. Personal accounts shall not be the sole repository of official records. Access shall be removed promptly when an office or authorised role ends.

213. Images, messages and pastoral contact. Consent shall be obtained before publishing identifiable photographs or personal testimony. Private messaging with children or vulnerable adults shall comply with safeguarding policy and use

accountable channels. Pastoral conversations online remain subject to boundaries, confidentiality limits, record requirements and referral duties.

PART XIV SERVICE, MISSION AND CREATION

214. Personal apostolate. Each professed member should maintain an appropriate expression of service, which may include pastoral care, food relief, community work, chaplaincy, environmental work, befriending, family caregiving or intercession.

215. Corporate apostolate. Where practicable, fraternities should undertake or support a common work of mercy.

216. Creation care. Members should consider the effects of consumption, travel, energy, waste, food and purchasing choices without adopting competitive or self-righteous attitudes.

217. Discernment of apostolate. A proposed ministry should answer a real need, be within the member's competence, respect existing services, have appropriate permission and insurance where required, include safeguarding and risk assessment, and remain proportionate to family, work and health. OSFC endorsement shall be explicit; personal initiatives shall not be presented as official works.

218. Missionary manner. Members should first witness through peaceable presence, service and humility. Explicit proclamation shall be offered only with respect for conscience and without exploiting need, grief or dependence. Members shall not promise healing, protection, financial benefit or ecclesiastical status, and shall refer matters beyond their competence.

PART XV HEALTH, AGE, DISABILITY AND LEAVE

219. Adaptation. Illness does not suspend vocation. Prayer and service obligations should adapt mercifully to health and capacity.

220. Elder members. Older and less mobile members should be honoured for prayer, experience and perseverance, and participation should be adapted rather than withdrawn.

221. Reasonable adjustments. Meetings, formation, liturgy and communication should be made accessible so far as reasonably practicable through suitable timing, breaks, captions, large print, remote access, mobility arrangements or other adjustments. A member should not be required to disclose more medical detail than is necessary to arrange support or assess safety.

222. Leave and reduced observance. A member facing significant illness, bereavement, caring duty, crisis or vocational uncertainty may request leave or an agreed period of reduced observance. Contact, expectations, office, representation, review date and pastoral support should be recorded. Leave is not punishment and should not result in abandonment by the fraternity.

PART XVI PASTORAL CONDUCT, SAFEGUARDING AND COMPLAINTS

223. Pastoral boundaries. Pastoral contact shall have a clear purpose, suitable setting and appropriate duration. Members shall not foster exclusivity, dependency or secrecy; enter romantic or financial relationships arising from a current pastoral relationship; use confession, spiritual direction or formation to obtain personal benefit; or exceed their competence. Touch shall be appropriate, non-coercive and sensitive to the other person.

224. Immediate safeguarding action. Where a child, vulnerable adult or any person may be in immediate danger, safety and civil reporting take precedence over internal consultation. The member shall not investigate, confront an alleged perpetrator or promise secrecy, but shall preserve available information, record facts promptly and contact the designated safeguarding and civil authorities as required.

225. Receiving a complaint. The recipient shall listen without defensiveness, thank the person for speaking, clarify immediate safety, explain next steps and confidentiality limits, and make a factual dated record. No member shall retaliate, pressure withdrawal, organise informal reputation management or circulate allegations beyond those who need to know.

226. Support and fairness. Complainants, respondents, witnesses and affected fraternities should be offered appropriate pastoral support from persons not deciding the matter. Protective measures are neutral and temporary. Information shall be shared on a need-to-know basis, but confidentiality shall not be misrepresented as secrecy or used to prevent lawful disclosure.

PART XVII OFFICE, ADMINISTRATION AND PERSONAL VOCATIONAL COSTS

227. Handover. On appointment, an office-holder should receive a written description of authority, responsibilities, policies, current actions, records and access credentials. On leaving office, all official property, records and access shall be transferred promptly. Personal copies of confidential material shall be securely deleted unless lawful retention is required.

228. Council practice. Council papers should be circulated securely in sufficient time. Minutes shall record attendance, conflicts, decisions, reasons where material, responsible persons and review dates. Executive action between meetings shall be reported and ratified where required. Confidential sessions should be exceptional and separately recorded.

229. Financing the vocation. Each member shall budget for his or her own vocation and pay providers directly for personal purchases, formation materials, travel, retreats and ministry expenses. Shared activities should be arranged with clear individual costs and direct payment to the provider, rather than through money held by the Order. Commitments should remain affordable, with suitable alternatives where necessary.

230. Records and data. Official records shall be factual, dated, attributable and stored in an approved location. Access shall follow role and need. Sensitive information shall not be kept in private messaging threads, unsecured devices or personal cloud

storage. Corrections shall preserve an audit trail. Retention and disposal shall follow LCAC policy, civil law and the Constitutions.

PART XVIII DEATH, REMEMBRANCE AND PASTORAL CARE OF THE BEREAVED

231. Dying. Where desired and possible, the Order should offer prayer, pastoral presence, Sacraments and support for family.

232. Funeral. A professed member may be buried or cremated accompanied by approved habit, cord, Tau or insignia, subject to the member's wishes and lawful rights of family.

233. Necrology. The Order shall maintain a Necrology and remember departed brothers and sisters in prayer.

234. Wishes and next of kin. Members are encouraged to record funeral wishes, next-of-kin details and any lawful preference concerning habit or insignia, and to ensure that executors and family know where these wishes are kept. OSFC shall respect the lawful rights and pastoral needs of family and shall not claim property or precedence because of profession.

235. Remembrance. The death should be communicated with verified facts and suitable consent. Fraternities should pray promptly, support the bereaved, and remember the member annually where practicable. Public tributes shall avoid disclosing private pastoral, medical, safeguarding or disciplinary information.

MINIMUM ORDINARY OBSERVANCE

Rhythm	Ordinary Practice
Daily	Morning Prayer; Evening Prayer; Scripture or spiritual reading; personal prayer; recollection or examination; prayer for the fraternity.
Weekly	Sunday Eucharist where reasonably possible; an act of mercy; Franciscan or theological study; a Friday penitential observance.
Monthly	Fraternity gathering where available; extended recollection; review of the Personal Rule.
Annually	Retreat; formal Personal Rule review; participation in Chapter or a major gathering where reasonably possible; renewal of Franciscan commitment where provided.

The Franciscan Test for Daily Life

- Is it Gospel?
- Is it loving and truthful?
- Is it simple and humble?

- Does it make peace?
- Does it respect another person's dignity?
- Does it serve rather than dominate?
- Could I do it openly before my brothers and sisters?
- Would Francis and Clare recognise Christ in this choice?

Conclusion of the Customary

236. Let the married Franciscan find Christ at the family table; the single Franciscan in generous availability; the worker in ordinary labour; the ordained member at the altar and among the people; the lay religious in the fullness of baptismal vocation; the sick in patient endurance; and the elderly in the treasury of prayer. Let every home become in some small way a friary or convent of the heart.

Pax et Bonum.

GENERAL CONCLUSION

237. The Rule, Constitutions and Customary now return the reader to the simplicity from which they began: the call to observe the Holy Gospel of Our Lord Jesus Christ after the examples of Saint Francis and Saint Clare. Every chapter, article, custom and safeguard serves this one end. The value of the document will not finally be measured by the fullness of its provisions, but by whether it assists real people to become more prayerful, truthful, humble, free, merciful and steadfast; whether it forms fraternities in which the vulnerable are protected, authority is exercised as service, difference is held within charity, and the gifts of every member are received for the common good.

238. Profession within the Order is therefore neither an escape from ordinary life nor a claim to spiritual distinction. It is a promise to find Christ and serve him precisely within the circumstances entrusted to each person: at the altar and the family table, in silence and public ministry, in paid work and hidden service, in strength and illness, in confident action and patient waiting. Members are called to hold possessions without possessiveness, exercise gifts without domination, speak truth without contempt, receive correction without despair and offer service without making another person dependent. They are to become lesser ones, not by denying their dignity, but by following the humility of the Incarnate Word.

239. The common life must always unite mercy and accountability. Mercy without truth can leave harm unaddressed; accountability without mercy can become punishment without hope. The Order is therefore to correct fraternally, safeguard diligently, govern transparently, keep faithful records, hear complaints impartially and seek restoration wherever restoration is truthful and safe. At the same time, it must remain a place where weakness can be acknowledged, help requested, burdens shared and a person permitted to begin again. In all things, the dignity of those affected, the protection of the vulnerable, the requirements of justice and the possibility of conversion are to be held together.

240. No member lives this vocation by personal strength alone. The grace of Christ is given through the Holy Spirit, the Sacraments, Holy Scripture, the communion of the Church, the witness of Francis and Clare, the patience of brothers and sisters, and the needs of those whom the Order is called to serve. For this reason, members should return often to the Gospel, renew the spirit of profession, review the Personal Rule honestly, seek reconciliation promptly and receive formation

throughout life. When observance becomes difficult, they should neither conceal the struggle nor abandon the path, but ask for the wisdom, accommodation, correction or support needed for faithful perseverance.

241. May all who receive this form of life do so freely, live it generously and hand it on faithfully. May their prayer become compassion, their simplicity become freedom, their fraternity become reconciliation, their work become praise, and their service become a credible sign of the Kingdom of God. May every household, fraternity and ministry of the Order be marked by peace and all good; and may the brothers and sisters, conscious of their limitations yet confident in divine mercy, begin again each day to follow the poor, humble, crucified and risen Christ, to whom with the Father and the Holy Spirit be all honour, glory and thanksgiving, now and for ever. Amen.

A 30-DAY READING AND REFLECTION PLAN

This plan is intended for prayerful formation rather than hurried completion. Each day, begin with a brief invocation of the Holy Spirit, read the assigned paragraphs slowly, note one phrase that calls for attention, consider the reflection question, and conclude with the suggested prayer or practice. The paragraph references correspond to the bold purple numbers in the main text. The subject index and glossary may be consulted as needed but are not assigned as daily readings.

Day	Reading	Theme and reflection	Prayer or practice
1	¶¶ 1–8	**Receiving the vocation.** How do the Rule, Constitutions and Customary together lead me towards Christ rather than mere regulation?	Offer the month to God. Write one sentence naming what you hope to receive.
2	¶¶ 9–18	**Franciscan identity and fraternity.** Which mark—humility, mercy, simplicity, joy, reverence or practical love—most needs to deepen in me?	Perform one quiet act of fraternal care without seeking recognition.
3	¶¶ 19–26	**Prayer and conversion.** What pattern of prayer can I live faithfully in my actual circumstances?	Keep ten minutes of silence and end with a simple examination of the day.
4	¶¶ 27–34	**The evangelical counsels.** Where am I being invited into greater freedom from possessiveness, control or self-will?	Choose one unnecessary possession, indulgence or demand to release.
5	¶¶ 35–42	**Family, work and dispersed life.** How can my home or workplace become a place of prayer, peace and reliable service?	Bless your home or workspace and make one practical act of reconciliation or support.
6	¶¶ 43–51	**Mission, peace and creation.** Does my witness begin with listening, humility and service?	Undertake one act of mercy or creation care suited to your circumstances.
7	¶¶ 52–62	**Formation, profession and perseverance.** What support or	Review one part of your Personal Rule, or draft a

		correction would help me persevere truthfully?	first practical commitment.
8	¶¶ 63–74	**Nature, charism and proper law.** How do law, pastoral safety and Franciscan minority serve the Gospel together?	Pray for those entrusted with ecclesial and religious authority.
9	¶¶ 75–84	**Membership, dignity and authority.** Do I honour different states of life without creating grades of spiritual worth?	Give thanks for a vocation different from your own and affirm its dignity.
10	¶¶ 85–97	**Admission, formation and profession.** What signs reveal readiness, freedom, maturity and safe participation?	Pray for inquirers, postulants, novices and those discerning profession.
11	¶¶ 98–110	**Chapter, Council and servant government.** How can consultation, records and recusal protect communion and trust?	Examine one responsibility you hold: is it exercised transparently and accountably?
12	¶¶ 111–120	**Fraternity, prayer and stewardship.** Does my use of time, money and property strengthen communion and mission?	Review one regular expense or use of time in the light of simplicity.
13	¶¶ 121–133	**Apostolate, conduct and safeguarding.** How do boundaries and due process express love rather than distrust?	Read your current safeguarding guidance or identify where it is kept.
14	¶¶ 134–146	**Leave, records, amendment and promulgation.** How can governance remain truthful, humane and orderly during change?	Pray for members who are ill, on leave, departing or carrying difficult decisions.
15	¶¶ 147–155	**The Franciscan day.** Which daily rhythm would make me more attentive to God and neighbour?	Practise the adapted daily Office and protect a short period from messages and media.
16	¶¶ 156–165	**The week, Sacraments and devotion.** How can worship continue in thanksgiving, penance and works of mercy?	Plan one Friday discipline and prepare intentionally for the Eucharist.
17	¶¶ 166–175	**Home, hospitality and possessions.** Is my hospitality safe, consensual and sustainable, and do my possessions serve love?	Make one place more prayerful and pass on one useful item you no longer need.
18	¶¶ 176–186	**Work and fraternity.** Where do reliability, rest, direct speech and mutual care need strengthening?	Contact a member who may be isolated, burdened or absent.
19	¶¶ 187–200	**Habit, insignia and formation customs.** Do outward signs correspond to humility, safety, truthfulness and readiness?	Examine one outward sign, title or role: does it clarify service or seek status?

20	¶¶ 201–209	**Feasts, retreat and annual review.** How can the Franciscan calendar and Personal Rule sustain lifelong conversion?	Choose a date for retreat or extended recollection and note one annual priority.
21	¶¶ 210–218	**Digital life, service and mission.** Does my online and public conduct reveal truthfulness, restraint and peace?	Observe a period of digital restraint and review one public profile or account.
22	¶¶ 219–226	**Health, disability, boundaries and complaints.** How can compassion, accessibility, immediate safety and fairness be held together?	Identify one reasonable adjustment or pastoral support that could widen participation.
23	¶¶ 227–236	**Administration, personal vocational costs, death and remembrance.** What practical order is needed so that ministry remains accountable and care continues well?	Update one record, handover note, funeral wish or next-of-kin detail.
24	¶¶ 237–241	**The whole vocation gathered in Christ.** Which sentence from the General Conclusion best expresses the life I am called to live?	Copy that sentence by hand and use it as your prayer throughout the day.
25	Re-read ¶¶ 1–18	**Gospel identity and belonging.** What has become clearer since the first days of the plan?	Write a brief personal statement of Franciscan intention.
26	Re-read ¶¶ 19–34	**Prayer, conversion and freedom.** Which counsel requires a concrete next step?	Choose one realistic practice for prayer, simplicity, chastity, obedience or minority.
27	Re-read ¶¶ 35–62	**Ordinary life, mission and perseverance.** Where is Christ asking to be served in my present circumstances?	Make a specific commitment of service for the coming month.
28	Re-read ¶¶ 63–146	**Healthy structures for Gospel life.** Which constitutional safeguard most protects people, vocation and trust?	Note one governance or safeguarding question to discuss with an appropriate officer.
29	Re-read ¶¶ 147–236	**Embodied and sustainable observance.** Which customs are essential for your Personal Rule, and what adaptations are honestly needed?	Draft or revise a sustainable daily, weekly, monthly and annual rhythm.
30	Re-read ¶¶ 237–241; consult the index and glossary	**Beginning again.** What grace, challenge and practical commitment will I carry beyond these thirty days?	Give thanks, pray for the Order, and record three commitments for the next ninety days.

COMPREHENSIVE SUBJECT INDEX

This index uses the bold purple paragraph numbers as stable references. Where an entry contains several references, the principal or most detailed treatment is shown first. Related concepts are linked by cross-references. All ordained and lay members' voluntary, unpaid and non-stipendiary service and responsibility for their own support are addressed in paragraphs 80, 117–120 and 176; personally purchased habit and insignia are addressed in paragraph 188. Paragraphs 118–120 concern personal provision, direct payment and sustainable observance, not the former financial-administration provisions.

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COMPREHENSIVE GLOSSARY

Term	Meaning in this document
Adaptation	A prudent adjustment of observance to health, disability, family, employment, poverty, travel or genuine necessity. Adaptation preserves the spirit and essential obligations of the vocation rather than abandoning them.

Annual covenant	A pastoral and accountability statement made at annual review, affirming adherence to the Rule, Constitutions, Customary, Code of Conduct and safeguarding requirements. It is not a renewal of perpetual profession.
Apostolate	A work or pattern of Christian service through which a member or fraternity shares in the mission of Christ, including mercy, pastoral care, caregiving, chaplaincy, intercession, peace-making and care for creation.
Apostolic Succession	The ecclesial continuity of ordained ministry through episcopal consecration, received within the LCAC's sacramental understanding. Membership or profession in OSFC does not itself confer Holy Orders or sacramental authority.
Associate or Companion	A person who shares in OSFC spirituality or works without making religious profession and without acquiring the rights and duties proper to professed members.
Balance of probabilities	The ordinary internal standard of proof under which a fact is found when it is more likely than not to have occurred, unless higher law requires another standard.
Canon Law	The body of ecclesiastical law governing the LCAC and matters within its lawful authority. OSFC proper law remains subject to applicable LCAC Canon Law.
Canonical	Relating to the law, discipline, records, authority or recognised ordering of the Church.
Charism	A gift of the Holy Spirit entrusted to a person or community for the good of the Church. The OSFC charism is Franciscan Gospel life expressed through prayer, simplicity, humility, minority, fraternity, reconciliation, service and reverence for creation.
Chastity according to state of life	Integrated, truthful and non-exploitative love lived faithfully within marriage, single life or a freely undertaken commitment to consecrated celibacy.
Civil authority	A lawful public authority, including police, courts, safeguarding bodies, regulators or emergency services. Internal church processes must not obstruct duties owed to civil authority.
Clarean	Relating to Saint Clare of Assisi and her spirituality, especially contemplation of Christ, evangelical poverty, steadfastness and tender mutual care.
Code of Conduct	The applicable LCAC or OSFC standards governing behaviour, boundaries, public witness, safeguarding, confidentiality and accountability.
Common good	The conditions and decisions that protect dignity, justice, safety, participation and flourishing for the fraternity, the Church and wider society rather than advancing merely private interests.
Competent authority	The person, council, Chapter, church officer or civil body lawfully empowered to decide or act in a particular matter.
Compline	The Church's night prayer, used to commend the day and the sleeper to God.

Conflict of interest	A personal, financial, familial, pastoral or other interest that may impair, or reasonably appear to impair, impartial judgement. It must be disclosed and may require recusal.
Consecrated celibacy	A freely discerned and distinct commitment to celibate life for God and service. It is not automatically required of every single or ordained OSFC member.
Constitutions	The part of OSFC proper law that gives stable juridical and communal form to the Rule by regulating membership, formation, profession, government, safeguarding, individual responsibility for financing vocation and administration.
Contemplation	Prayerful, loving attention to God, especially through Christ, Scripture, silence and the Sacraments, which leads to conversion and loving action.
Conversion	The lifelong turning of mind, heart and conduct towards God. In Franciscan life it includes repentance, amendment, reconciliation and renewed conformity to Christ.
Customary	The practical part of OSFC proper law describing the ordinary embodiment of the Rule and Constitutions in daily, weekly, sacramental, fraternal and administrative life.
Directory	A body of subsidiary practical regulations or guidance adopted under the Constitutions for matters requiring more detail or periodic revision.
Discernment	Prayerful and evidence-based seeking of God's will through Scripture, conscience, counsel, lived fruit, circumstances and the judgement of the Church or fraternity.
Dismissal	The involuntary ending of membership for sufficiently grave cause through a lawful process that includes notice, opportunity to respond, a reasoned decision and appeal.
Dispersed life	A form of religious life in which members ordinarily live in their own homes, families and local communities rather than in one common residence, while remaining united by profession, prayer, formation, mutual care and mission.
Due process	A fair procedure including clear notice, a meaningful opportunity to respond, impartial consideration, proportionate action, reasons and an appropriate right of review or appeal.
Ecclesial	Relating to the Church as the Body of Christ, its sacramental communion, mission, ministry, authority and discipline.
Evangelical counsels	The Gospel disciplines of poverty or simplicity, chastity and obedience. OSFC also stresses minority as the characteristic Franciscan form of humble service.
Faculties	Formal ecclesiastical permissions granted by competent church authority to exercise specified ordained or pastoral ministries. Profession and office in OSFC do not automatically confer faculties.
Formator or Formation Companion	A person appointed to accompany, teach, assess and review someone in formation while respecting boundaries, confidentiality, freedom and the distinction between formation and therapy.

Franciscan	Relating to the Gospel way associated with Saint Francis and Saint Clare of Assisi, marked by humility, poverty of spirit, fraternity, peace, joy, reverence, contemplation and service.
Franciscan Crown	A traditional Franciscan rosary-like devotion honouring seven joys of the Blessed Virgin Mary.
Fraternity	The spiritual family and concrete network of mutual responsibility formed by OSFC members. It may be local, regional, national or digital.
Friar	A male member of the Franciscan religious family. Within OSFC, friars and sisters share equal religious dignity.
General Chapter	The principal deliberative and elective assembly of OSFC, responsible for elections, major policy, reports, formation, amendments and future direction, subject to lawful LCAC authority.
General Council	The collegial governing body that assists the Minister General and shares responsibility for significant decisions, oversight and administration.
Guardian or Local Minister	A member entrusted with pastoral and administrative service within a local or regional fraternity. The role does not confer unrestricted authority.
Habit	Approved Franciscan religious dress worn as a sign of simplicity, fraternity and witness, never as proof of sacramental authority or personal superiority.
Holy Orders	The sacrament of ordained ministry. Religious profession neither confers nor removes Holy Orders, and ordained status does not automatically confer OSFC office.
Inquirer	A person exploring the OSFC vocation before formal admission to postulancy.
LCAC	The Liberal Catholic Apostolic Church, within which OSFC lives its sacramental, liturgical and ecclesial vocation and whose lawful Canon Law and competent authority bind the Order where applicable.
Lectio divina	A prayerful reading of Scripture involving attentive reading, meditation, prayer and contemplation, allowing the Word to shape life.
Leave	A temporary, recorded adjustment or pause in ordinary participation because of illness, bereavement, family responsibility, work, crisis or vocational discernment. It is not punishment.
Legitimate authority	Authority lawfully conferred and exercised within its proper limits, consistently with the Gospel, conscience, safeguarding, civil law and the rights of persons.
Minority	The Franciscan choice to be a lesser brother or sister: serving without domination, privilege, entitlement or status, and standing in solidarity with people who are overlooked or excluded.
Minister General	The principal religious superior and servant of OSFC, guardian of the Rule and representative of the Order, acting within the Constitutions and with appropriate collegial accountability.

Natural justice	Basic procedural fairness, especially impartial decision-making, the opportunity to know and answer a case, and freedom from conflicts of interest.
Necrology	The official record of deceased members maintained so that they may be remembered in prayer.
Novice	A person formally admitted to the novitiate for systematic formation and discernment before any religious profession.
Novitiate	The structured period, ordinarily at least twelve months, in which a novice studies, prays, serves, participates in fraternity and tests readiness for profession.
Obedience	Attentive listening to God through the Gospel, prayer, conscience, Church, Rule, legitimate authority and fraternity. It never requires unlawful, abusive, degrading or unsafe conduct.
Oblation	A voluntary gift or offering. OSFC does not impose compulsory oblations, and no Sacrament, pastoral care or admission decision may be made conditional upon payment.
Office	A defined role of service, authority or administration within OSFC. Office is limited by its mandate, requires accountability and may be held by suitable lay or ordained members unless ordination is intrinsic to the role.
OSFC	The Order of Saints Francis and Clare, a Franciscan religious order of the LCAC governed by its Rule, Constitutions, Customary and other lawful norms.
Pastoral boundaries	Limits that keep ministry purposeful, safe, non-exploitative and free from secrecy, dependency, coercion, inappropriate intimacy or personal gain.
Pastoral care	Prayerful, compassionate accompaniment offered within competence and authority, with truthful explanation of confidentiality, safeguarding and referral limits.
Penance	Practices of repentance, self-restraint, almsgiving, service and amendment of life that express conversion without harming health or becoming a measure of status.
Perpetual profession	A lifelong, freely made public commitment to live the Holy Gospel according to the OSFC Rule and proper law.
Personal Rule of Life	An individual, reviewed application of the common Rule to prayer, Eucharist, Scripture, simplicity, family, work, penance, fraternity, service, rest, study and health. It does not replace the common Rule.
Portiuncula	The small chapel of Our Lady of the Angels closely associated with Saint Francis and the beginnings of the Franciscan movement; its observance recalls humility, fraternity and mission.
Postulant	A person formally admitted to an introductory period of prayer, participation, formation and vocational discernment before the novitiate.
Profession	The public and ecclesially received promise to live the Gospel according to the Rule in simplicity, chastity according to state of life, obedience, minority, fraternity and service.

Promulgation	The formal act by which a duly approved law or text is officially issued and given effect.
Proper law	The internal law particular to OSFC, principally the Rule, Constitutions, Customary, Directory and lawful decisions or regulations adopted under them, subject to higher applicable law.
Protective measure	A temporary, neutral restriction imposed to protect persons or processes while a serious concern is assessed or investigated. It is not itself a finding of guilt.
Quorum	The minimum number or proportion of eligible participants required for an assembly to transact valid business.
Reasonable adjustment	A practicable change to communication, timing, access, format or participation that enables a disabled or otherwise limited person to take part safely and fairly.
Recusal	Withdrawal from discussion, investigation or decision-making because of a conflict of interest, prior involvement or reasonable concern about impartiality.
Reconciliation	The restoration of right relationship through truth, repentance, forgiveness, reparation and peace where possible and safe. It never requires concealment of harm or resumption of unsafe contact.
Register of Professions	The secure official record of temporary and perpetual professions, including the person, date, rite and receiving authority.
Release	The lawful freeing of a perpetually professed member from the obligations of profession following petition and any required ecclesiastical process.
Restorative steps	Proportionate actions intended to acknowledge harm, repair what can be repaired, protect those affected, change conduct and rebuild trust where truthful and safe.
Rule	The foundational spiritual form of OSFC life, setting forth the Gospel vision by which the Constitutions, Customary and all practice are interpreted.
Sacramental seal	The absolute confidentiality attached, under applicable church law, to sacramental confession heard by an authorised cleric. It is distinct from ordinary pastoral confidentiality.
Safeguarding	The policies, duties and actions by which children, vulnerable adults and others are protected from abuse, grooming, coercion, exploitation, neglect and avoidable harm.
Safeguarding Lead	The designated person responsible for receiving concerns, coordinating appropriate church action and ensuring referral to civil authorities where law or safety requires.
San Damiano Cross	The icon cross associated with Saint Francis's call to rebuild Christ's Church and often used as a Franciscan focus for prayer.
Scrupulosity	An unhealthy pattern of excessive moral or religious anxiety. The document rejects observance that feeds fear, false precision or self-accusation rather than trust and conversion.

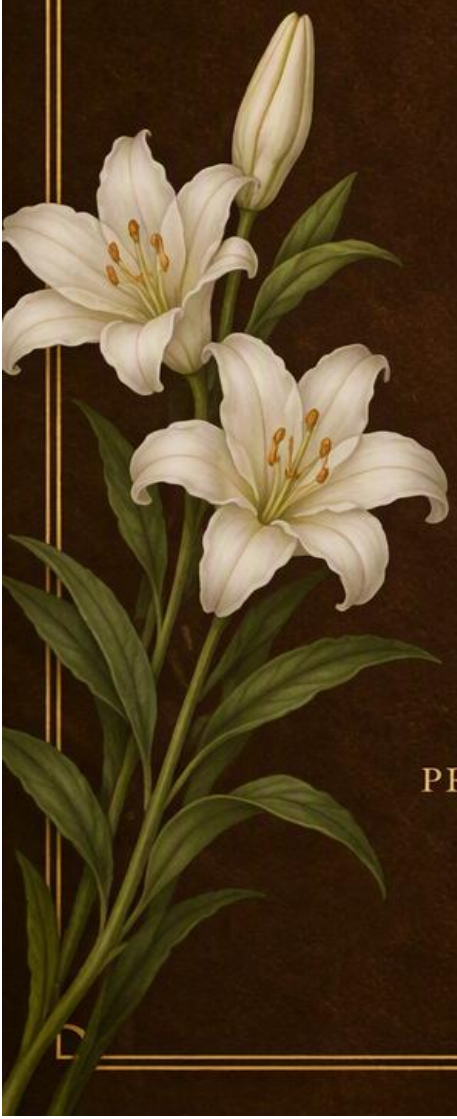
Simplicity	Franciscan freedom from possessiveness, excess, display and greed, joined to prudent provision, stewardship, generosity and solidarity with people who are poor.
Sister	A female member of the Franciscan religious family. Within OSFC, sisters and friars share equal religious dignity.
Spiritual communion	Prayerful union with Christ in the Eucharist when sacramental reception is not possible, practised according to LCAC usage.
Spiritual direction	Confidential spiritual accompaniment helping a person attend to God's action and discern faithful response. It must respect competence, boundaries and safeguarding.
Subsidiary norms	Formation, safeguarding, liturgical, electoral or other regulations adopted under the Constitutions and consistent with higher law, including provisions for individual responsibility for financing vocation.
Tau	The T-shaped biblical and Franciscan cross used as a sign of repentance, blessing and belonging to Christ.
Temporary profession	A time-limited religious profession, ordinarily renewed annually, through which a member lives the professed vocation while continuing discernment before perpetual profession.
Transitus	The Franciscan commemoration of the passing of Saint Francis from death to eternal life, customarily observed on the evening before his feast.
Vulnerable adult	An adult who, because of care needs, disability, illness, circumstances, dependency or another factor recognised by law or policy, may be at increased risk of abuse or unable to protect themselves adequately.

Lord,
make me an instrument
of your peace:
where there is hatred, let me sow love;
where there is injury, pardon;
where there is doubt, faith;
where there is despair, hope;
where there is darkness, light;
and where there is sadness, joy.

— *Prayer of St Francis*

"We become what we love
and who we love shapes
what we become."

— *Saint Clare of Assisi*



ORDER OF SAINTS FRANCIS AND CLARE

PRAYER · SIMPLICITY · SERVICE
PEACE · CREATION